

Interviewing for research

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**‘The interview is probably the most widely employed method in qualitative research’
Bryman and Bell (2011: 465)**

Why use interviews?

Disadvantages of interviews as a research method?

Structured interviews

- exactly the same questions asked of each interviewee

Semi-structured interviews

- a number of 'stem questions', with scope to follow up and probe, depending on what the interviewee says

Leading the interview

In leading a research interview your main aim is to help the interviewee to provide information.

To do this, you need to: (O'Leary, 2010: 202-205)

1. take care of preliminaries
2. ease respondents into the interview
3. ask questions that facilitate answers
4. effectively manage the process

Leading the interview

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To do this, you need to: (O'Leary, 2010: 202-205)

1. take care of preliminaries
2. ease respondents into the interview
3. ask questions that facilitate answers
4. effectively manage the process
5. wind down at the right time

You need...

To have a strategy

To encourage the interviewee to talk

To listen more than you talk

Avoid :

Leading questions

Questions the interviewee can't understand

Multiple questions – eg 'Do you have a hands-on style of management, or do you believe that your team members can motivate themselves?'

Non-questions disguised as questions

A case for using interviews:

Suppose you want to carry out an analysis of how two leaders perceive their roles, and what has helped them develop as leaders

Planning:

Who can you access?

How can you structure an interview to gather this information from two leaders?

The direct approach....

How do you perceive your role?

What has helped you to develop as a leader?

Do you think of yourself as a leader or as a manager?

Would you describe yourself as a participative or a directive leader?

How would you describe your leadership style?

What does your job involve?

How many people work for you? (How many report to you directly?)

What do you see as the priorities in your job?

How do you tend to work with the people who report to you? (picking up on something the interviewee says, Can you give me an example of a time when you did that?)

Apart from the people who report to you, who else do you need to influence in your job? (picking an example, How do you go about influencing X?)

Suppose you were moving on to another role, what advice would you give someone who was going to move into your current job?

What has helped you to develop the knowledge and skills you need to be effective in your role? (pick on aspects of this and probe, eg: When you say Y was important as a mentor, what did he/she do in particular that helped you to develop?)

Remember:

Your main aim is to help the interviewee to provide information.

Create and maintain rapport.

Recording the interview

Notes or audiotape?

Summary:

The reasons for using interviews for research, and their limitations

Types of interview you can use

Advice on leading the interview and what to avoid

Some examples of how to formulate questions

Issues of recording interview data

Other videos in this series explore particular research interview strategies, and also how you can analyse interview data

If you are not used to using interviews for research, it is very important to practise!

References

Alan Bryman & Emma Bell 2011 *Business Research Methods*, Oxford, Oxford University Press – [now in a new edition](#):

Emma Bell, Alan Bryman and Bill Harley 2018 *Business Research Methods*, Oxford University: Press: Oxford ch 20 'Interviewing in qualitative research' pp. 433-461

Zina O'Leary 2010 *The Essential Guide to Doing Your Research Project*, Sage 'Direct Data Collection: Surveys and Interviews' pp 180-207 – [now in a new edition](#):

Zina O'Leary 2017 *The Essential Guide to doing your research project*, Sage ch 12 'Primary Data: Surveys, Interviews and Observation' pp. 223-262

#A chapter from these books is available as part of the e-resources for this module

Further reading

*Martyn Denscombe 2007 *The Good Research Guide*, OU/McGraw Hill

#Pervez Ghauri and Kjell Gronhaug 2010 *Research Methods in Business Studies* FT Prentice Hall: Harlow

#Michael Wilson and Roger Sapsford 2006 'Asking Questions' from Roger Sapsford and Victor Jupp (eds) *Data Collection and Analysis* 2nd ed Sage: London

#Gina Wisker 2008 *The Postgraduate Research Handbook* 2nd ed Palgrave Macmillan: Basingstoke

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* This is an e-book in the YSJ University library